Roots Against the Storm

Field report · Sundarbans, Khulna, Bangladesh · Example upload for testing

The mangrove forest at the edge of the delta is both a workplace and a shield. When cyclones strike, the dense roots slow the storm surge before it reaches the villages behind the embankments. Years of cutting and shrimp farming have thinned the forest, and the last major cyclones broke embankments that had protected farmland for decades.

The project follows a group of women who run a mangrove nursery and replant mudflats each monsoon. Their husbands and sons collect crabs and wild honey deep in the forest, where Bengal tigers still hunt and where every trip carries risk. Rising salinity has made rice farming harder, so the forest has become more important to household income.

The photographs move between the nursery, the mudflats at low tide and the narrow channels where the collectors work, and show a community restoring the ecosystem that protects it.

Method

Over two monsoon seasons the photographer accompanied the nursery group on planting days and joined collectors on short trips into the forest with local guides. Interviews were recorded with consent, and the names of people photographed are kept by the photographer.

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